



Kunzite

△ **Scissors-cut**, 17-carat gem of the spodumene variety kunzite

Kunzite is the pink variety of the mineral spodumene, and is named after the American gemologist G F Kunz, who first described it in 1902. Faceting-grade kunzite shows strong pleochroism – two different shades of the body colour when viewed from different directions. Gems must be carefully oriented to show the best colour through the top surface; additionally, kunzite tends to be splintery, and slivers are likely to break off during cutting if the stone is not oriented correctly. Kunzite and other spodumene gems are almost always faceted.

Specification

Chemical name	Lithium aluminosilicate		Formula	
$\text{LiAl}(\text{Si}_2\text{O}_6)$	Colour	Pink	Structure	Monoclinic
Hardness	6.5–7	SG	3.0–3.2	RI 1.66–1.68
Lustre	Vitreous	Streak	White	Locations Afghanistan, Brazil, Madagascar, USA



Gem-grade kunzite crystal | Rough | This piece of kunzite rough displays excellent colour and transparency, and can be cut into a fine and valuable gem.



Elongated crystal | Rough | This crystal is 11cm (4¼in) long, and it can be cut into a desirable stone. The colour is light and delicate rather than intense.



Fancy heart shape | Cut | The finest kunzite, when cut by a master cutter, produces some of the finest gems, as this high-quality specimen demonstrates.



Kunzite ring | Set | Kunzite gems are often set among colourless diamonds to emphasize their colour – here, the faceted stone is surrounded by white gold and diamonds.



Kunzite earrings | Set | Set with diamonds and smaller pink sapphires in 18-karat white gold, these pendant earrings feature two oval-cut kunzites each.

Picasso necklace | Set | Designed by Paloma Picasso, this necklace of baroque pearls features a dazzling 396.3-carat kunzite from Afghanistan mounted in gold and accentuated by diamonds.

